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DURING BUD MCFARLANE'S visit to Bethesda Naval Hospital and in following meetings, he informed me that representatives of Israel had contacted him secretly to pass on information from a group of moderate, politically influential Iranians. These Iranians, described as disenchanted members of Iran's government, wanted to establish a quiet relationship with U.S. leaders as a prelude to reestablishing formal relations between our countries following the death of the Ayatollah Khomeini. Bud asked my approval to meet with the Iranians to see if it might lead somewhere.

At that time, there were reports worldwide that the ayatollah was extremely ill. Iran's protracted war against Iraq had reached a stalemate, the Iranian economy was in bad shape, and intelligence reports indicated that several factions had formed to jockey for control of Iran after the ayatollah's death. From our point of view, reestablishing a friendly relationship with this strategically located country—while preventing the Soviets from doing the same thing—was very attractive. Under the shah, Iran had played a pivotal role in our efforts to keep an eye on its neighbor, the USSR. We wanted to ensure that the next government in Teheran was moderate and friendly.

Through quiet diplomacy, we had been trying to end the Iran-Iraq war and reduce instability in the Middle East, which we saw as an invitation to Soviet tampering. We had also spent a great deal of time thinking about possible scenarios for Iran's future once Khomeini was gone. Before becoming president, I had visited Iran, a short time before the shah was ousted, and had met many ordinary Iranian citizens in